

CORE FORMULA

Observation -> Feeling -> Need -> Request -> When X happened, I felt Y, because I need Z. Would you be willing to do A? -> "When the report went out without my name on it, I felt overlooked, because credit matters to me. Would you add it before the next send?" -> Use the structure to organise your thinking, then speak like a person.

MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Say one plain observation, one feeling, the need under it, and one doable request — four short sentences, no jargon, no naming the steps.

BEST FOR

- Conflict repair and clearing the air
- Setting a boundary without attacking
- Emotionally charged requests
- Repairing a relationship after friction
- Raising a recurring irritation before it festers
- Asking someone to change a specific behaviour

PHRASE BANK

Plain openers · Quick starters

- "Can I put something plainly?"
- "There's something I'd like to name, then ask you about."
- "I'd rather say this than sit on it."
- "Mind if I tell you what I noticed and what I'd like?"
- "Here's the short version — stop me if I've got it wrong."
- "One thing's been on my mind. Can I say it?"
- "Small thing, but worth clearing up."

Say what you saw, not what it meant · Clean observations

- "When the meeting ran twenty minutes over?"
- "The last three replies came back after midnight?"
- "I noticed the report went out without my name on it?"
- "Twice this week the plan changed after we'd agreed it?"
- "When you said "we'll see" and then it didn't happen?"
- "Not "you never listen" — "the last two times I raised this, we moved on quickly.""
- "I'm working from what I saw, not what I assumed — tell me if I've misread it."

Name the feeling and the need · Feeling plus need

- "I felt overlooked, and I think it's because being counted matters to me."
- "I got anxious, mostly because I need a bit more certainty about timing."
- "Honestly, I felt hurt — I care about us being straight with each other."
- "I ended up frustrated, because I really value being kept in the loop."
- "I'm feeling stretched, and what I need is a little more warning."
- "I felt shut out, and connection matters more to me than being right."
- "That left me uneasy — I work better when I know where I stand."

Make one clear, doable request · The ask

- "Would you be willing to give me a heads-up next time?"
- "Could we agree to lock the plan by Thursday?"
- "Would you add my name before the next send?"
- "Can we keep phones down at dinner?"
- "Would you be open to a quick check-in each Friday?"
- "Could you tell me directly if something's off, rather than going quiet?"
- "Is now a good time, or should we find a better one?"

Soften, check, and back out gracefully · Repair and check-back

- "Have I got that right, or am I missing something?"
- "That came out sharper than I meant — let me try again."
- "I'm not blaming you; I'm trying to sort this out with you."
- "If this isn't the moment, tell me and we'll pick it up later."
- "You don't have to agree — I just wanted to be honest about it."
- "Tell me how that lands from your side."
- "I might be wrong about the why. What was actually going on?"

When it's heated · Conflict and pressure

- "Can we both slow this down for a second?"
- "I want to get this right more than I want to win it."
- "Here's the one thing I most need you to hear."
- "I'm going to say the hard part plainly, then listen."
- "I'm not trying to score a point — I want us okay."
- "Let's stick to what happened before we get to what it meant."
- "If I've hurt you, I want to know that first."

Email and text · Digital / async

- "Quick note: two things landed late this week and it threw my planning."
- "Not urgent — I'd like ten minutes to talk through how the handover went."
- "One ask: could we confirm the date by Friday?"
- "I'd rather say this in person than over text — free later?"
- "Short version: I felt out of the loop on the change. Can we reset how we flag these?"
- "No drama, just want to name it and agree a fix."
- "Sending this so it's not a surprise when we talk."

WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Announces the framework and forces every sentence into Observation, Feeling, Need, Request.
Better: Uses the four steps silently to organise a shorter, clearer response.
Best: Moves through the steps invisibly, then checks whether the other person feels clearer and more heard.
2. Weak: Dresses a judgement up as an observation — "you always do this."
Better: States a plain fact both of you would recognise.
Best: Names the fact so cleanly the other person nods before you've even reached the feeling.
3. Weak: Ends with a vague complaint or a flat demand.
Better: Ends with a specific, doable request.
Best: Makes a request the other person can genuinely say no to — and means it.

DECISION TREE

If They need it fast

Compress to the minimum move — one observation, one need, one request.

"When X happened I felt Y; would you be willing to do A?"

If They're upset first

Validate before you structure anything.

"Before I get to the ask — that sounded genuinely rough."

If They want the picture, not a formula

Switch to a story-shaped neighbour like STAR or CARL.

"Let me just tell you how it actually went."

If They need a decision or next step

End on one clean, doable request.

"So the one thing I'm asking is?"

If They challenge the framing

Drop the structure, summarise, and invite correction.

"Tell me where I've got this wrong."

If Emotion is very high or safety is in question

Stop structuring; keep it human or step away.

"Let's pause this — you matter more than the point."

SCENARIOS

Work meeting

Compress to one observation and one request so it lands and moves on. — "We agreed Tuesday, then it shifted twice — can we lock it now?"

Email

Break the four steps into short, scannable lines the reader can take in at a glance. — "What happened / how it left me / what I need / the ask — one line each."

Giving feedback

Check what kind of feedback they want before you structure anything. — "Do you want the quick version or the whole picture?"

Difficult conversation at home

One sentence per step, then stop and listen. — "When plans change last-minute I get anxious, because I need a bit of warning. Could we agree a cut-off?"

Setting a boundary

Keep the observation neutral so the boundary doesn't read as an attack. — "When calls come after nine I can't wind down — I need my evenings. Can we keep work to daytime?"

Repairing after a row

Validate the hurt first, then use the structure lightly. — "That landed badly and I get why. Here's what I actually meant?"

WHEN NOT TO USE

- Physical safety or an immediate emergency — act first, talk later
- When you would be weaponising vulnerability to get your way
- Manipulative or pressuring requests dressed up as needs
- The other person has not agreed to process deep emotion
- A steep power imbalance where "sharing feelings" is not safe for them
- You only want to vent, with no request behind it

7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

Day 1 — Learn the four steps

Write out Observation, Feeling, Need and Request from memory, each in one plain sentence, for any small situation from today.

Day 2 — Spot the disguised judgement

Take three "you always / you never" complaints and rewrite each opening as a neutral observation both people would agree on.

Day 3 — Name feeling and need

Pick one recurring irritation. In a single sentence, name the feeling it stirs and the need sitting underneath it — no blame words allowed.

Day 4 — Write it, then cut it

Draft a full 60-second OFNR for a real situation, then cut it by a third without losing the observation, need or request.

Day 5 — Mechanical vs human

Say the same OFNR aloud twice — once naming the steps, once as ordinary speech — and note how much warmer the second sounds.

Day 6 — Use the minimum move live

In one low-stakes real moment, use the four-sentence minimum move and watch whether the other person gets clearer or more defensive.

Day 7 — Run it on something that matters

Take one genuinely charged issue, work the full move, and have one recovery line ready in case it lands badly.

AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did the structure serve the other person, or just make me sound polished?
- Was my observation a fact, or a judgement in disguise?
- Did I name a real feeling and the need under it — not a demand?
- Was there one clear request they could actually say no to?
- Did I stay human, or did I sound like I was reciting?
- If it landed badly, did I back up and simplify?